CENTRAL AMERICA (including the Caribbean)

OSTA RICA (1 February)

Harvesting of the 2000/01 second season cereal crop has been completed. Output of maize (white) is expected to be lower than last yearï¿½s as a result of the lower area planted. Paddy production in the year 2000 (January/December) was a record 329 000 tonnes. For the 2001 agricultural campaign early forecasts indicate that the planting intentions may be slightly reduced.

Wheat imports in the current marketing year 2000/01 (July/June) will probably increase, in line with the observed expansion in domestic demand of recent years. Maize imports, mostly yellow, also expected to increased in the marketing year 2000/01 (July/June) relative to the previous period as a consequence of an increase in the demand for animal feed.

UBA (1 February)

Abundant rains during December helped to partially replenish water reservoirs which were low from last yearï¿½s dry spell. These reservoirs are important in view of the forthcoming first season crop due to start in March. However, the high humidity caused by the intensive rains affected the quality of paddy crops, and did not favour the concentration of nutrients in sugar cane. The sugar cane crop currently being harvested had earlier been affected by drought, and its output is likely to decrease compared to last yearï¿½s 4.1 million tonnes. The rains receded in January, which helped to improve the quality of paddy and sugar cane crops.

Wheat imports in marketing year 2000/01 are forecast to remain at about the previous yearï¿½s 900 000 tonnes. Yellow maize imports in the current marketing year (July/June) are also expected to be close to those of the previous year, which amounted to about 260 000 tonnes.

OMINICAN REPUBLIC (1 February)

Agricultural activities are progressing normally thanks to the favourable weather conditions that prevail in the main producing zones of the country. Land is being prepared for planting the forthcoming 2001 first season coarse grain crops in March, while planting of this yearï¿½s paddy crop is underway. Weather conditions have also benefited the development of other minor food crops.

Wheat imports in marketing year 2000/01 (July/June) are expected to increase from last yearï¿½s 277 000 tonnes to some 300 000 tonnes. Imports of maize are also expected to increase so as to satisfy the increasing demand for feed. Rice imports in marketing year 2001 (January - December) are expected to be about 70 000 tonnes.

L SALVADOR (20 February)

The country has been hit by a series of earthquakes since January. On 13 January 2001 a severe earthquake killed over 800 people and totally or partially destroyed more than 140 000 homes, particularly in the vicinity of the capital city. Emergency food aid and other types of relief assistance are being provided by the international community to the affected families in urban and peri-urban areas. Official reports indicate that the worst hit agricultural sector was the important export-oriented coffee industry. Damage to cereal crops was minimum, as the event occurred at a time when the harvesting of the second season crop had already been completed. A second earthquake in mid-February killed over 270 people. As the first and second season maize crops had earlier been affected by adverse weather conditions, so total production for the 2000 campaign is expected to decline from the previous yearï¿½s 650 000 tonnes to about 570 000 tonnes. Rice and beans outputs are expected to be average compared to the previous years. A major concern for the government is the 2000/01 first season crop, due to be sown from April-May. It is feared that the total area cultivated may be reduced following the disruptions caused by the earthquake on infrastructure, labour and agricultural imports in general.